



Ick-a-thon 2026

Problem Statement Title - Doomscrolling steals youth's free time,
with no easy way out

Team Name - **Flame Kaiser**

Team Member Details -

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Our solution: Terrarium: Focus Debt, a Chrome extension that swaps the scroll for a task

IEEE Women in Engineering
WIE

The Assigned Ick (Problem Statement)

Proposed Solution (Describe your Idea/Solution/Prototype)

What is the everyday inconvenience? What exactly happens? Who experiences it?

- **"Just 5 minutes"**: you open Reels or Shorts and look up an hour later.
- **No stopping point**: infinite feeds, autoplay and swipe-to-next never end.
- **The cost**: tired, anxious, behind on work, sleeping late.
- **Who**: students and young adults, mostly late at night and between classes.
- **Blockers don't stick**: one tap on "ignore limit" and you're back in.

5 min → **60+ min**
planned actually lost

46% of US teens say they are
online "almost constantly"
Pew Research Center, Dec 2024

Our Take on the Ick

How we understood the problem and what we decided to focus on

- **Catch the moment:** the urge wins in the first few seconds, so we act right then.
- **Replace, don't remove:** blockers leave a gap, so people bypass them.
- **Not all of YouTube is bad:** lectures and DMs stay untouched; only feeds count.
- **Focus:** Shorts, Reels and home feeds, weighted more late at night.

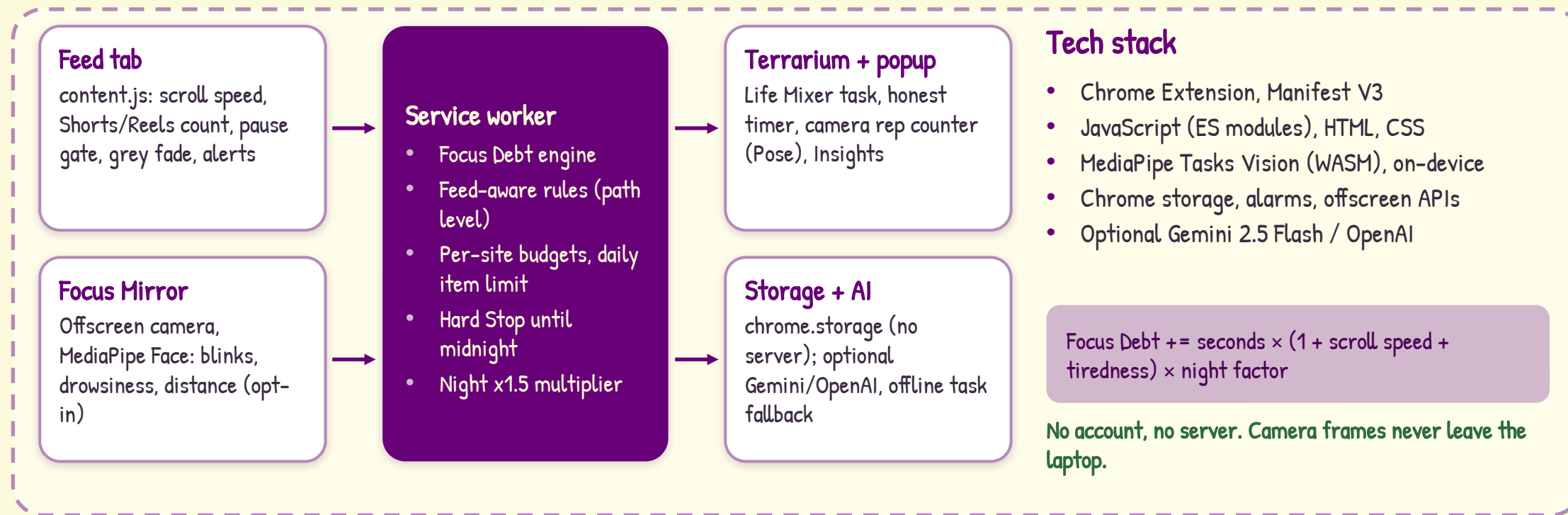
Our approach to solving it and the key idea involved in it.

"We don't block the scroll. We swap it."

- 1 **Pause** 5-sec breath: why are you here, and for how long?
- 2 **Measure** Focus Debt grows with time, scroll speed, late nights
- 3 **Nudge** page fades to grey; 20-20-20 eye-break reminders
- 4 **Swap** pay the debt with one 15-min task picked by mood
- 5 **Stop** Hard Stop locks feeds till tomorrow; your plant grows

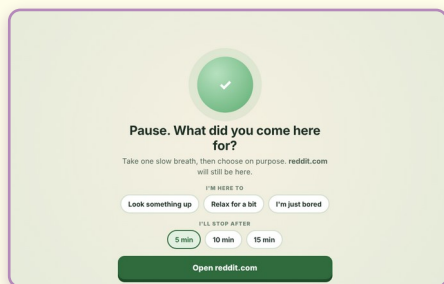
Technical Implementation

What we built, tech stack used and how it works. Simple workflow / architecture (if any)



Project Screenshots

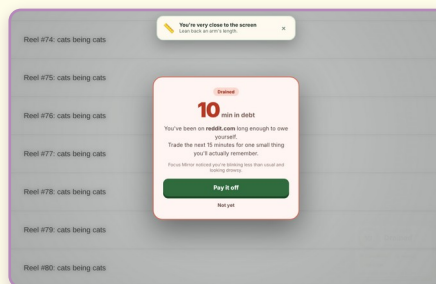
Working prototype / demo screenshots, main features and key user flow



1

Pause

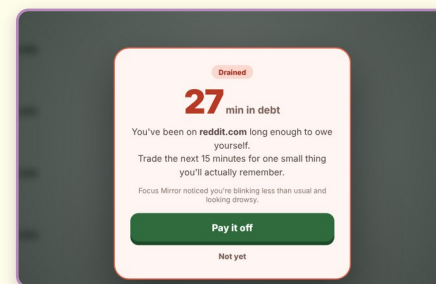
A 5-second breath, then "what did you come for?"



2

Track

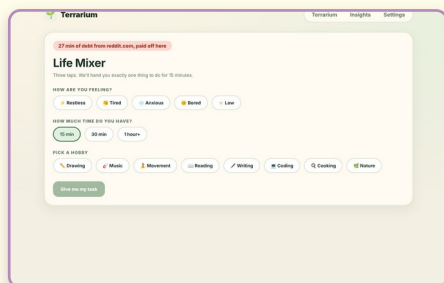
Debt gauge, grey fade and eye-break tips



3

Alert

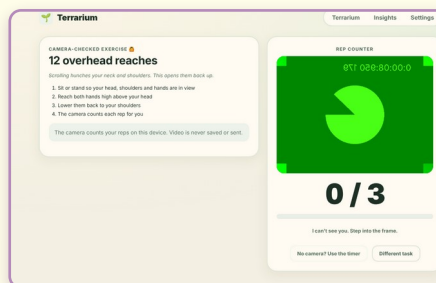
At 10 min of debt: pay it off with one task



4

Swap

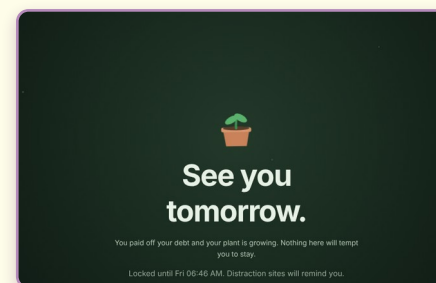
Life Mixer: mood + time + hobby = one task



5

Verify

Camera counts your exercise reps on the laptop



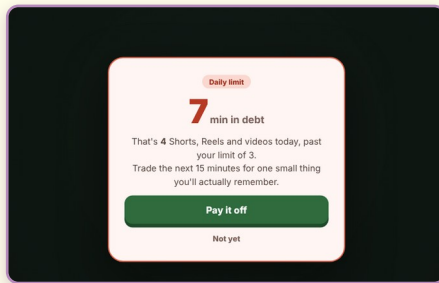
6

Stop

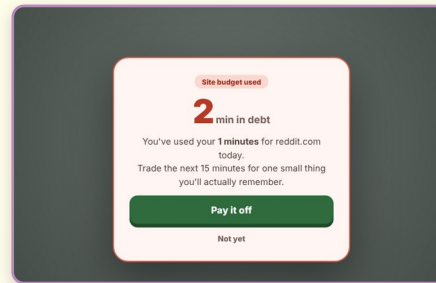
Hard Stop: feeds locked until tomorrow

Project Screenshots (contd.)

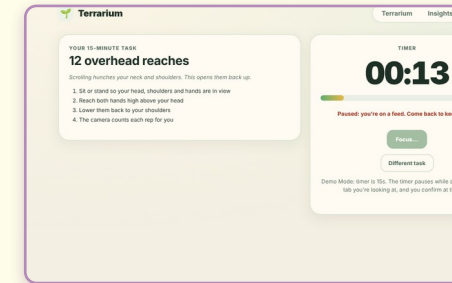
Working prototype / demo screenshots, main features and key user flow



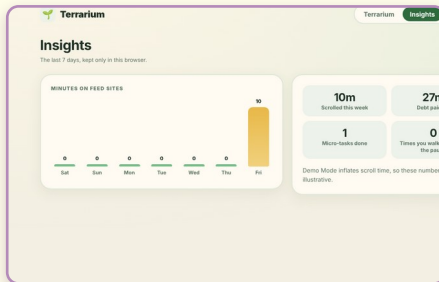
1
Feed-aware
Lectures untouched; Shorts counted, daily limit



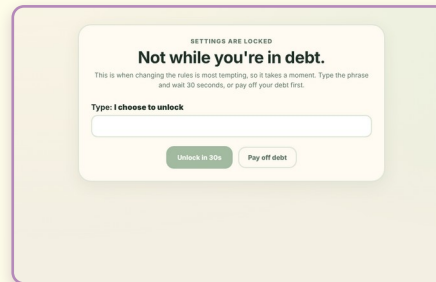
2
Budgets
Daily minute budget for each site



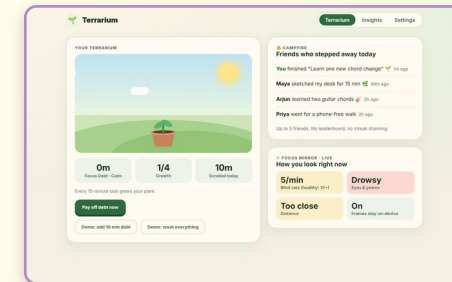
3
Honest timer
Pauses while a feed tab is open



4
Insights
7 days of scroll time, debt paid, tasks



5
Settings lock
In debt? Type a phrase, then wait half a minute



6
Grow
Plant grows; Campfire friends; Focus Mirror

Us vs Existing Extensions

How we differ from the anti-doomscroll extensions already on the Chrome Web Store, and the trade-offs

	Doomscroll Blocker	Doomscroll Fog	Doomscroll protection	Terrarium (ours)
How it works	Fade + reminder after set scrolling	Blur builds after set time	Only the first Short plays	Pause, Focus Debt, task, Hard Stop
Lectures safe?	Whole-site blocklist	Per-site on / off	YouTube Shorts only	✓ Feed pages only + budgets
Something to do instead	✗	✗	✗	✓ 15-min task or exercise
Hard to bypass	—	Snooze button	—	✓ Hard Stop + settings lock
Stats	—	Daily scroll totals	✗	✓ Popup + 7-day Insights

Trade-offs we chose

Bigger download (~23 MB): the AI runs on your laptop, not a server

Only exercise is camera-checked; other tasks trust your honesty

Chrome desktop only for now; phone apps are future scope

Stricter than a blocker on purpose; Settings tune every rule

Competitor details are from their Chrome Web Store listings (Oct 2026), not hands-on testing.